WRITE TOGETHER HUB

Editing Checklist

A three-stage guide: structure first, then style, then polish.

Work top to bottom. Finish each stage before you start the next — never polish sentences in a chapter you might still cut.

Stage 1 · Structural / Developmental Edit

The big picture: story, structure, and character.

- ☐ The premise is clear and compelling
- ☐ Every scene advances the plot or reveals character
- ☐ The three-act structure and key beats land
- ☐ The middle doesn't sag — stakes keep escalating
- ☐ Every subplot pays off or is cut
- ☐ The protagonist has a clear, earned arc
- ☐ The antagonist's motivation is credible
- ☐ Point of view is consistent and purposeful
- ☐ The timeline is consistent throughout
- ☐ The setting is grounded and vivid
- ☐ Theme emerges through story, not lecture
- ☐ The opening hooks within the first pages
- ☐ The ending satisfies the setups you planted

Stage 2 · Line Edit

Clarity, flow, and style — sentence by sentence.

- ☐ Every paragraph earns its place
- ☐ Sentence length and rhythm vary
- ☐ Filter words trimmed (saw, felt, noticed, realized)
- ☐ Weak verbs + adverbs replaced with strong verbs
- ☐ Emotion is shown, not named
- ☐ Redundancy and throat-clearing cut
- ☐ Dialogue sounds natural and distinct per character
- ☐ Dialogue tags are mostly “said”
- ☐ Sensory detail is present but not overloaded
- ☐ Clichés replaced with fresh language
- ☐ Passive voice fixed where it weakens the line
- ☐ Transitions between scenes are clear

Stage 3 · Copyedit & Proofread

Correctness and consistency — the final polish.

- ☐ Spelling and typos fixed
- ☐ Grammar and punctuation correct
- ☐ Tense is consistent
- ☐ Spelling style consistent (e.g. -ise vs -ize)
- ☐ Character names and details consistent
- ☐ Proper nouns capitalized consistently
- ☐ Dialogue punctuation is correct
- ☐ Numbers and dates formatted consistently
- ☐ Chapter headings styled consistently
- ☐ Scene breaks and page breaks correct
- ☐ Front and back matter present and correct
- ☐ Run a spellcheck, then read aloud for a final pass

Final pre-submission checks

- ☐ Title page and copyright page in place
- ☐ Table of contents accurate (if used)
- ☐ Formatting consistent across the file
- ☐ Clean copy exported in the required format